

# Minimal winding in the self-similar collapse of three point vortices and of two concentric vortex polygons

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**Abstract.** In a self-similar collapse of point vortices every vortex moves on a logarithmic spiral, and the dimensionless number  $P = |\omega_0| t_c$ , the initial angular velocity times the collapse time, measures how tightly the spiral winds. We minimize  $P$  over two classical collapsing families. Every self-similar collapse of three point vortices can be normalized to circulations  $(1, \mu, -\mu/(1+\mu))$  with  $0 < \mu \leq 1$  and zero angular impulse. For each  $\mu$  the collapsing configurations form two arcs, one for each orientation of the vortex triangle, and  $P$  has exactly one critical point, a minimum, on each. The squares of the two minima are roots of an explicit cubic whose coefficients are polynomials in  $\mu$ , and for  $\mu < 1$  the two minima differ. The smaller one increases strictly from  $\sqrt{3}/2$ , approached as  $\mu \rightarrow 0$ , to  $\sqrt{2}$  at  $\mu = 1$ . Hence  $P > \sqrt{3}/2$  for every self-similar collapse of three point vortices, and the constant is sharp; equivalently, every vortex travels more than twice its initial distance from the collision point. For  $\mu = 1/2$  the two minima are 1.0647059762... and 2.2038550160..., the positive roots of  $8748\xi^6 - 49005\xi^4 + 27794\xi^2 + 18723$ , and they are not expressible by real radicals. For two concentric regular  $n$ -gons with circulations  $x_n$  and  $-1$ ,  $P = (K_n - \sqrt{2n-1} \cos n\theta)/(2n \sin n\theta)$  in terms of the relative rotation  $\theta$ , with an explicit constant  $K_n$ , and the minimum over  $\theta$  is  $\sqrt{K_n^2 - 2n + 1}/(2n)$ ; for pentagons it is  $\sqrt{31682}/80$ . All formulas are also checked against the Biot–Savart velocities in high-precision arithmetic.

**Keywords:** point vortices; vortex collapse; self-similar motion; logarithmic spiral.

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## 1. Introduction

Three point vortices collapse self-similarly only if  $1/\Gamma_1 + 1/\Gamma_2 + 1/\Gamma_3 = 0$  and their angular impulse about the center of vorticity vanishes (Lemma 2 below). Under these conditions every configuration moves self-similarly: the triangle keeps its shape and rotates while it shrinks to a point in finite time, expands, or rotates rigidly [1, 13]. Such collapse was found by Gröbli [9] and found again by Aref [1] and by Novikov and Sedov [16], who also constructed collapsing configurations of four and five vortices; see [4] for the history and [15] for the general theory. Kimura [10] studied similarity solutions of point-vortex systems, Aref [3] derived formulas for the rate of collapse or expansion and the angular frequency of rotation, and Gotoda [8] gave explicit formulas for the self-similar motions of three vortices. Borisov and Lebedev [5] obtained conditions for the collapse and the scattering of three vortices within the Lie–Poisson formulation of the problem, and Krishnamurthy, Aref and Stremmer [12] recast the motion of three vortices in terms of the circumcircle and the interior angles of the vortex triangle and derived equations of motion for these quantities. Collapse also occurs in configurations of higher symmetry. Aref [2] reduced the motion of two concentric regular  $n$ -gons of vortices to an integrable Hamiltonian system with two degrees of freedom, and Koiller et al. [11] found collapsing configurations of two such rings, whose vortices move on logarithmic spirals.

In a self-similar collapse at time  $t_c$  the configuration has rotated by time  $t$  through the angle  $-\omega_0 t_c \ln(1 - t/t_c)$ , where  $\omega_0$  is the initial angular velocity. The angular velocity at time  $t$  is

$\omega_0 t_c / (t_c - t)$ , so the product of the angular velocity and the remaining time does not depend on which instant is taken as initial. Each vortex moves on a logarithmic spiral about the collision point, whose exponent is fixed by this product [3, Eq. (29)], and the dimensionless number  $P = |\omega_0| t_c$ , which is invariant under rescaling of lengths, times and circulations, is the angle through which the configuration turns while the square of its size decreases by the factor  $e$ . Equivalently, the path of each vortex makes the constant angle  $\arctan 2P$  with the direction to the collision point, and a vortex that starts at distance  $r_0$  from that point travels the distance  $r_0 \sqrt{1 + 4P^2}$  before the collapse. Within a collapsing family it is natural to ask which configuration winds least.

For three vortices we answer this question completely (Section 3). After normalization the circulations are  $(1, \mu, -\mu/(1 + \mu))$  with  $0 < \mu \leq 1$ . The collapsing configurations form two arcs, one for each orientation of the triangle, and  $P$  has a unique minimum on each (Theorem 1). For  $\mu < 1$  the two minima differ, and the smaller one increases strictly with  $\mu$ , from  $\sqrt{3}/2$  as  $\mu \rightarrow 0$  to  $\sqrt{2}$  at  $\mu = 1$ , the value for two equal circulations. Thus  $P > \sqrt{3}/2$  for every self-similar collapse of three vortices, and the bound is sharp (Corollary 1). For  $\mu = 1/2$  the two minima are conjugate algebraic numbers of degree six, given explicitly in Proposition 1. In Section 4 we treat two concentric regular  $n$ -gons, for which the minimization reduces to an elementary inequality once  $P$  is written in a suitable form. Section 5 describes an independent numerical check.

## 2. Self-similar collapse

The positions  $z_j \in \mathbb{C}$  of point vortices with circulations  $\Gamma_j$  evolve according to

$$\dot{z}_j = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \sum_{k \neq j} \frac{\Gamma_k}{z_j - z_k}. \quad (1)$$

Suppose  $\sum_j \Gamma_j \neq 0$ , let  $z_c = \sum_j \Gamma_j z_j / \sum_j \Gamma_j$  be the center of vorticity, which is conserved, and suppose that at  $t = 0$  there is  $\kappa \in \mathbb{C}$  with  $\dot{z}_j = \kappa(z_j - z_c)$  for all  $j$ . The right-hand side of (1) is homogeneous of degree  $-1$  in the relative positions and equivariant under rotations, so the solution is  $z_j(t) = z_c + \lambda(t)e^{i\varphi(t)}(z_j(0) - z_c)$  with  $\lambda\dot{\lambda} = \text{Re } \kappa$  and  $\lambda^2\dot{\varphi} = \text{Im } \kappa$ . Hence  $\lambda^2 = 1 + 2t \text{Re } \kappa$ . If  $\text{Re } \kappa < 0$  the vortices collide at  $z_c$  at the time  $t_c = -1/(2 \text{Re } \kappa)$ , and  $\omega_0 = \text{Im } \kappa$ , so that

$$P = |\omega_0| t_c = \frac{|\text{Im } \kappa|}{-2 \text{Re } \kappa}. \quad (2)$$

Integrating  $\dot{\varphi} = \omega_0/\lambda^2$  gives  $\varphi = -P \ln \lambda^2$  when  $\omega_0 > 0$ , which is the description of the spiral given in the introduction. The angular impulse about the center of vorticity satisfies

$$\sum_j \Gamma_j |z_j - z_c|^2 = \frac{1}{\sum_j \Gamma_j} \sum_{j < k} \Gamma_j \Gamma_k |z_j - z_k|^2. \quad (3)$$

It is conserved and, in a self-similar motion, proportional to  $\lambda^2$ , so it must vanish for a collapse. Two of the minimizations below (Remark 2 and Proposition 2) reduce to the following elementary inequality.

**Lemma 1.** *Let  $a > |b|$ . For  $0 < \alpha < \pi$ ,  $(a - b \cos \alpha)/\sin \alpha \geq \sqrt{a^2 - b^2}$ , with equality if and only if  $\cos \alpha = b/a$ .*

*Proof.* The numerator is positive, and  $(a - b \cos \alpha)^2 - (a^2 - b^2) \sin^2 \alpha = (a \cos \alpha - b)^2$ . □

### 3. Three vortices

#### 3.1. Normalization and the collapsing configurations

The Hamiltonian  $H = -(4\pi)^{-1} \sum_{j < k} \Gamma_j \Gamma_k \ln |z_j - z_k|^2$  of (1) is conserved. We call a collapse self-similar if all mutual distances are  $\lambda(t)$  times their initial values, with  $\lambda(t) \rightarrow 0$  in finite time.

**Lemma 2.** *In a self-similar collapse of three point vortices all circulations are nonzero,  $1/\Gamma_1 + 1/\Gamma_2 + 1/\Gamma_3 = 0$ ,  $\sum_j \Gamma_j \neq 0$ , and the angular impulse about the center of vorticity vanishes.*

*Proof.* The harmonic condition and the vanishing of the angular impulse are the classical necessary conditions [3, Sect. II B] (see also [5, Sect. 3]); we include the short argument. Along the motion

$$H = H(0) - \frac{1}{4\pi} \left( \sum_{j < k} \Gamma_j \Gamma_k \right) \ln \lambda^2,$$

and  $\ln \lambda^2 \rightarrow -\infty$ , so  $\sum_{j < k} \Gamma_j \Gamma_k = 0$ . If one circulation vanished, this would force a second one to vanish; the remaining vortex would then be at rest and the other two would move on circles about it, so no collapse would occur. Hence all  $\Gamma_j \neq 0$ , and  $\sum_{j < k} \Gamma_j \Gamma_k = \Gamma_1 \Gamma_2 \Gamma_3 \sum_j 1/\Gamma_j$  gives the harmonic condition. Moreover  $\left( \sum_j \Gamma_j \right)^2 = \sum_j \Gamma_j^2 > 0$ . Finally, the angular impulse (3) is conserved and proportional to  $\lambda^2$ , so it vanishes.  $\square$

By Lemma 2 two of the three circulations of a self-similarly collapsing configuration have the same sign. Multiplying all circulations by a positive constant rescales time and leaves  $P$  unchanged. Multiplying them by  $-1$  reverses time, and so does complex conjugation of the positions, which maps solutions of (1) to solutions; the composition maps collapsing solutions to collapsing solutions with the same  $P$ . After relabeling we may therefore assume, as Gotoda does [8, Sect. 3],

$$\Gamma = \left( 1, \mu, -\frac{\mu}{1+\mu} \right), \quad 0 < \mu \leq 1. \quad (4)$$

Then  $\sum_j \Gamma_j = R/(1+\mu) > 0$ , where  $R = 1 + \mu + \mu^2$ . For  $w = (z_3 - z_1)/(z_2 - z_1)$  the sum  $\sum_{j < k} \Gamma_j \Gamma_k |z_j - z_k|^2$  in (3) equals  $\mu(1+\mu)^{-1} |z_2 - z_1|^2 (1 + 2\mu \operatorname{Re} w - (1+\mu)|w|^2)$ , which vanishes exactly on the circle  $|w - \mu/(1+\mu)| = \sqrt{R}/(1+\mu)$ . This is the circle of Aref [3, Eq. (20)], and we use the parametrization of it given by Gotoda [8, Sect. 3]:

$$z_1 = \frac{\mu(1 + \sqrt{R}e^{-i\theta})}{(1+\mu)^2}, \quad z_2 = \frac{\mu - \sqrt{R}e^{-i\theta}}{(1+\mu)^2}, \quad z_3 = 1, \quad \theta \in [0, 2\pi). \quad (5)$$

Here  $\sum_j \Gamma_j z_j = 0$ , so  $z_c = 0$ , and

$$z_1 - z_2 = \frac{\sqrt{R}e^{-i\theta}}{1+\mu}, \quad z_3 - z_1 = \frac{\sqrt{R}(\sqrt{R} - \mu e^{-i\theta})}{(1+\mu)^2}, \quad z_3 - z_2 = \frac{\sqrt{R}(\sqrt{R} + e^{-i\theta})}{(1+\mu)^2}. \quad (6)$$

The shape ratio is  $w = \mu/(1+\mu) - (\sqrt{R}/(1+\mu))e^{i\theta}$ , which traverses the zero-impulse circle exactly once, so every zero-impulse configuration is obtained, up to translation, rotation and dilation, for exactly one  $\theta$ . Since  $\operatorname{Im} w = -(\sqrt{R}/(1+\mu))\sin \theta$ , the triangle  $z_1 z_2 z_3$  is negatively oriented for  $\sin \theta > 0$  and positively oriented for  $\sin \theta < 0$ . Put  $C = \sqrt{R} \cos \theta$  and

$$N(C) = 2(1 + \mu^2)R + (1 - \mu)(2 + \mu + 2\mu^2)C - 2\mu C^2, \quad M(C) = 1 - \mu + 2C.$$

**Lemma 3.** For every  $\theta$  the three quotients  $\dot{z}_j/(z_j - z_c)$  are equal to

$$\kappa = \frac{i(1 + \mu)^3}{2\pi\sqrt{R}} \cdot \frac{\sqrt{R} + (1 - \mu)e^{i\theta}}{(\sqrt{R} - \mu e^{i\theta})(\sqrt{R} + e^{i\theta})},$$

and, with  $D = (R + \mu^2 - 2\mu C)(R + 1 + 2C) > 0$ ,

$$\operatorname{Re} \kappa = -\frac{(1 + \mu)^3 \mu M(C) \sin \theta}{2\pi\sqrt{R}D}, \quad \operatorname{Im} \kappa = \frac{(1 + \mu)^3 N(C)}{2\pi R D}.$$

Moreover  $N(C) > 0$  for every  $\theta$ .

*Proof.* Since  $z_c = 0$  and  $z_3 = 1$ ,  $\kappa = \dot{z}_3$ , and by (1),  $\overline{\dot{z}_3} = (2\pi i)^{-1}((z_3 - z_1)^{-1} + \mu(z_3 - z_2)^{-1})$ . Inserting (6) gives the stated  $\kappa$ . The same computation for  $j = 1$  and  $j = 2$  gives the same value, as it must, since these configurations move self-similarly [10, 13]. The real and imaginary parts follow on multiplying numerator and denominator by the complex conjugate of the denominator, since  $|\sqrt{R} - \mu e^{i\theta}|^2 |\sqrt{R} + e^{i\theta}|^2 = D$ . The two factors of  $D$  are at least  $(\sqrt{R} - \mu)^2$  and  $(\sqrt{R} - 1)^2$ , which are positive because  $R > \mu^2$  and  $R > 1$ . Finally,  $N$  is concave in  $C$ , and  $N(\sqrt{R})N(-\sqrt{R}) = 3\mu^2(1 + \mu)^2 R$  and  $N(\sqrt{R}) + N(-\sqrt{R}) = 4R(1 - \mu + \mu^2)$  are positive, so  $N > 0$  on  $|C| \leq \sqrt{R}$ .  $\square$

By Lemma 3 every zero-impulse configuration rotates in the positive sense, and it collapses exactly when  $M(C) \sin \theta > 0$ . Let  $\theta_0 \in (0, \pi)$  be defined by  $\cos \theta_0 = (\mu - 1)/(2\sqrt{R})$ . The configurations with  $\theta = 0$  and  $\theta = \pi$  are collinear, and those with  $\theta = \pm\theta_0$  are equilateral triangles; these four are relative equilibria. The collapsing configurations form the two arcs

$$\mathcal{A}_+ = (0, \theta_0), \quad \mathcal{A}_- = (\pi, 2\pi - \theta_0),$$

the triangle being negatively oriented on  $\mathcal{A}_+$  and positively oriented on  $\mathcal{A}_-$ , and on them (2) gives

$$P(\theta) = \frac{N(C)}{2\mu\sqrt{R}M(C)\sin\theta}, \quad C = \sqrt{R}\cos\theta. \quad (7)$$

Since  $z_j(-\theta) = \overline{z_j(\theta)}$ , the reflection  $\theta \rightarrow -\theta$  maps  $\mathcal{A}_+$  and  $\mathcal{A}_-$  onto the expanding arcs  $(2\pi - \theta_0, 2\pi)$  and  $(\theta_0, \pi)$ .

### 3.2. The minimal winding

Let  $u = \mu + 1 + 1/\mu \geq 3$  and  $Q(\mu, y) = \mu^6 \tilde{Q}(u, y)$ , where

$$\begin{aligned} \tilde{Q}(u, y) = & 1728(u + 1)^2 y^3 - 144(u + 1)(8u^3 - 9u - 9)y^2 \\ & - 4(16u^6 - 288u^4 - 288u^3 - 81u^2 - 162u - 81)y + 3(4u^3 - 3u - 3)^2. \end{aligned} \quad (8)$$

Then  $Q$  is a polynomial in  $\mu$  and  $y$  with integer coefficients, irreducible over  $\mathbb{Q}$ . Its discriminant with respect to  $y$  is

$$28311552 \mu^4 (\mu - 1)^2 (\mu + 1)^4 (\mu + 2)^2 (2\mu + 1)^2 R^6 B^3,$$

where  $B = 4\mu^6 + 12\mu^5 + 51\mu^4 + 82\mu^3 + 51\mu^2 + 12\mu + 4$ ; the sum of the roots of  $Q(\mu, \cdot)$  is  $(8u^3 - 9u - 9)/(12(u + 1)) > 0$ , and their product is  $-((4u^3 - 3u - 3)/(24(u + 1)))^2 < 0$ . Hence for  $0 < \mu < 1$  the cubic  $Q(\mu, \cdot)$  has three distinct real roots, one negative and two positive, which we denote  $y_1(\mu) < y_2(\mu)$ .

**Theorem 1.** *Let  $0 < \mu \leq 1$ .*

(a) *On each of  $\mathcal{A}_+$  and  $\mathcal{A}_-$  the function  $P$  has exactly one critical point, and it is the minimum of  $P$  on that arc. Denote the two minima by  $P_+(\mu)$  and  $P_-(\mu)$ .*

(b)  *$P_+(\mu)^2$  and  $P_-(\mu)^2$  are roots of  $Q(\mu, \cdot)$ . For  $\mu < 1$ ,  $P_-(\mu)^2 = y_1(\mu)$  and  $P_+(\mu)^2 = y_2(\mu)$ , so  $P_-(\mu) < P_+(\mu)$ ; for  $\mu = 1$ ,  $P_+ = P_- = \sqrt{2}$ .*

(c) *The least value of  $P$  over the collapsing configurations,  $P_-(\mu)$ , is strictly increasing on  $(0, 1]$ , and  $P_-(\mu) \rightarrow \sqrt{3}/2$  as  $\mu \rightarrow 0^+$ .*

*Proof.* (a) A direct computation from (7) gives

$$\frac{dP}{d\theta} = -\frac{G(C)}{2\mu M(C)^2 \sin^2 \theta},$$

where

$$G(C) = 4(1 - \mu)C^3 + 4(2\mu^2 - \mu + 2)C^2 + 2(1 - \mu)^3C - (2\mu^4 + 7\mu^3 + 6\mu^2 + 7\mu + 2). \quad (9)$$

As  $\theta$  runs over  $\mathcal{A}_+$ ,  $C$  decreases monotonically from  $\sqrt{R}$  to  $C_0 = (\mu - 1)/2$ ; over  $\mathcal{A}_-$  it increases from  $-\sqrt{R}$  to  $C_0$ . The critical points on the two arcs therefore correspond to the roots of  $G$  in  $(C_0, \sqrt{R})$  and in  $(-\sqrt{R}, C_0)$ . Now  $G(\pm\sqrt{R}) = \pm\sqrt{R}N(\pm\sqrt{R})M(\pm\sqrt{R})/R$ , which is positive because  $M(\sqrt{R}) > 0 > M(-\sqrt{R})$ , and  $G(C_0) = -3(1 + \mu)^4/2 < 0$ . So  $G$  has a root in each interval. For  $\mu < 1$ ,  $G$  is a cubic with positive leading coefficient, so it also has a root below  $-\sqrt{R}$ , and each interval contains exactly one root. For  $\mu = 1$ ,  $G = 12C^2 - 24$ , with one root in each of  $(-\sqrt{3}, 0)$  and  $(0, \sqrt{3})$ . The function  $P$  is differentiable on each arc, and at the ends of each arc  $M(C)\sin\theta \rightarrow 0$  while  $N > 0$ , so  $P \rightarrow +\infty$ ; hence the single critical point is the minimum.

(b) At a critical point  $G(C) = 0$ , and since  $R\sin^2\theta = R - C^2$ , the number  $y = P^2$  satisfies  $4\mu^2y(R - C^2)M(C)^2 = N(C)^2$ . The resultant of these two polynomials with respect to  $C$  is  $-48\mu^4(1 + \mu)^8Q(\mu, y)$ , so  $P_\pm(\mu)^2$  are roots of  $Q(\mu, \cdot)$  for  $\mu < 1$ . For  $\mu = 1$ ,  $P_\pm = \sqrt{2}$  by Remark 2 below. For  $0 < \mu < 1$  both are positive roots, hence each lies in  $\{y_1(\mu), y_2(\mu)\}$ . The three roots of  $G$  are simple, so  $P_+(\mu)$  and  $P_-(\mu)$  depend continuously on  $\mu$ , and so do  $y_1(\mu) < y_2(\mu)$ . By connectedness each of  $P_+^2$  and  $P_-^2$  coincides with the same  $y_i$  on all of  $(0, 1)$ . At  $\mu = 1/2$  the proof of Proposition 1, which uses only (a) and the first part of (b), gives certified enclosures  $P_-^2 \in [0.99, 1.30]$  and  $P_+^2 \in [4.70, 5.02]$ , each containing exactly one root of  $Q(1/2, \cdot)$ ; so  $P_-^2 = y_1$  and  $P_+^2 = y_2$ .

(c) For  $0 < \mu < 1$  the roots  $y_i(\mu)$  are simple, hence differentiable, and  $y'_i = -(\partial Q/\partial\mu)/(\partial Q/\partial y)$ . A zero of  $y'_1$  at some  $\mu$  would be a common root of  $Q(\mu, \cdot)$  and  $(\partial Q/\partial\mu)(\mu, \cdot)$ , but their resultant with respect to  $y$ ,

$$7044820107264\mu^7(\mu - 1)^3(\mu + 1)^7(\mu + 2)^3(2\mu + 1)^3R^6EB^3,$$

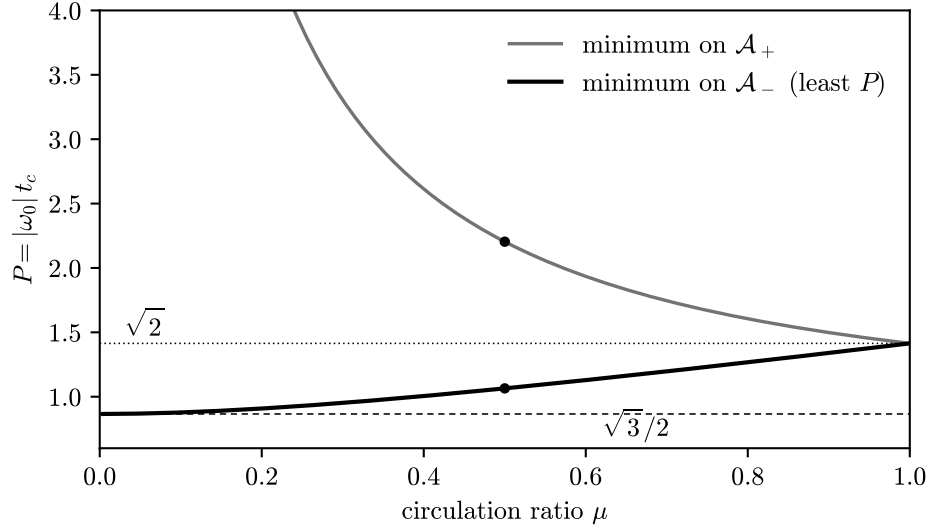


Figure 1: The minima  $P_-(\mu)$  and  $P_+(\mu)$  of  $P = |\omega_0| t_c$  on the two collapsing arcs, as functions of the circulation ratio  $\mu$ . The dots mark  $\mu = 1/2$  (Proposition 1). As  $\mu \rightarrow 0$ ,  $P_-$  tends to  $\sqrt{3}/2$  and  $P_+$  grows without bound.

where  $E = 4\mu^6 + 12\mu^5 + 21\mu^4 + 22\mu^3 + 21\mu^2 + 12\mu + 4$ , has no zero in  $(0, 1)$ . So  $y_1$  is strictly monotone on  $(0, 1)$ . The leading coefficient of  $Q(\mu, \cdot)$  does not vanish at  $\mu = 1$ , so the roots stay bounded as  $\mu \rightarrow 1^-$ , and  $y_1$  tends to a nonnegative root of  $Q(1, \cdot)$ , which is 2. Since  $y_1(1/2) = 1.1335... < 2$ ,  $y_1$  is increasing, and therefore  $y_1(\mu) < 2 = P_-(1)^2$  for  $\mu < 1$ . As  $\mu \rightarrow 0^+$  it therefore decreases to a limit  $L \geq 0$ , which is a root of  $Q(0, y) = -16(4y - 3)$ , so  $L = 3/4$ .  $\square$

**Corollary 1.** *Every self-similar collapse of three point vortices has  $|\omega_0| t_c > \sqrt{3}/2$ , and for every  $\delta > 0$  there is one with  $|\omega_0| t_c < \sqrt{3}/2 + \delta$ . Equivalently, each vortex travels more than twice its initial distance from the collision point, and the factor 2 is sharp.*

*Proof.* By Lemma 2, the normalization (4) and Theorem 1,  $P \geq P_-(\mu) > \sqrt{3}/2$ , and  $P_-(\mu) \rightarrow \sqrt{3}/2$  as  $\mu \rightarrow 0^+$ . The path length is  $r_0\sqrt{1 + 4P^2} > 2r_0$ , and no vortex starts at the collision point, since  $z_1, z_2$  and  $z_3$  in (5) never vanish.  $\square$

Every collapse of three point vortices in the plane is self-similar [7, Theorem 1.1], [13], so the bound of Corollary 1 holds for every collapse of three point vortices.

The two minima are shown in Figure 1.

### 3.3. The ratio $\mu = 1/2$

For  $\Gamma = (1, 1/2, -1/3)$  we have  $R = 7/4$  and  $\cos \theta_0 = -\sqrt{7}/14$ , and (7) becomes

$$P(\theta) = \frac{14 \sin^2 \theta + 6\sqrt{7} \cos \theta + 21}{2(14 \cos \theta + \sqrt{7}) \sin \theta}.$$

**Proposition 1.** *Let  $X = 245351/5201^{3/2}$  and  $\sigma = 7\sqrt{5201}/162$ . For  $\mu = 1/2$ ,*

$$P_- = \sqrt{\frac{605}{324} + \sigma \cos\left(\frac{1}{3} \arccos X - \frac{2\pi}{3}\right)} = 1.0647059762712043...,$$

$$P_+ = \sqrt{\frac{605}{324} + \sigma \cos\left(\frac{1}{3} \arccos X\right)} = 2.2038550160361327...,$$

attained at  $\cos \theta = -0.9243893679...$  and  $\cos \theta = 0.6739838839...$  respectively. Both are roots of the polynomial  $8748\xi^6 - 49005\xi^4 + 27794\xi^2 + 18723$ , which is irreducible over  $\mathbb{Q}$  and whose real roots are exactly these two numbers and their negatives.

*Proof.* Here  $16Q(1/2, \xi^2) = 8748\xi^6 - 49005\xi^4 + 27794\xi^2 + 18723$ , and by Theorem 1(b) the squares of both minima are roots of this polynomial. As a cubic in  $q = \xi^2$  it is irreducible over  $\mathbb{Q}$  and has positive discriminant, so its roots are real and are given by the trigonometric solution of the cubic,  $q_m = 605/324 + \sigma \cos(1/3 \arccos X - 2\pi m/3)$ ,  $m = 0, 1, 2$ , with  $q_0 \approx 4.856977$ ,  $q_1 \approx 1.133599$  and  $q_2 \approx -0.388724$ . The critical points are the roots of  $G$  in the two intervals of the proof of Theorem 1(a); with  $C = (\sqrt{7}/2) \cos \theta$  they are at the stated values of  $\cos \theta$ . Exact sign changes of  $G$  place them in  $0.67 < \cos \theta < 0.68$  on  $\mathcal{A}_+$  and  $-0.93 < \cos \theta < -0.92$  on  $\mathcal{A}_-$ , and interval arithmetic applied to  $P^2 = N^2/(4\mu^2(R - C^2)M^2)$  on these intervals gives  $P_+^2 \in [4.70, 5.02]$  and  $P_-^2 \in [0.99, 1.30]$ . Each enclosure contains exactly one of  $q_0, q_1, q_2$ , so  $P_+^2 = q_0$  and  $P_-^2 = q_1$ .  $\square$

**Remark 1.** The two minima are conjugate algebraic numbers of degree six. Since the cubic in  $q$  is irreducible over  $\mathbb{Q}$  and has three real roots, none of its roots is expressible by real radicals (casus irreducibilis), and therefore neither minimum is. The same holds for every rational  $\mu = a/b \in (0, 1)$  with  $b \leq 30$ : for each of these 277 values,  $Q(\mu, \xi^2)$  is irreducible over  $\mathbb{Q}$ .

**Remark 2.** For  $\mu = 1$ , that is  $\Gamma = (1, 1, -1/2)$ , the zero-impulse circle is  $|w - 1/2| = \sqrt{3}/2$ . With  $w = 1/2 + (\sqrt{3}/2)e^{i\beta}$ ,  $z_1 = 0$  and  $z_2 = 1$ , the same computation gives  $P = (3 - \cos 2\beta)/(2 \sin 2\beta)$  on the collapsing arcs  $0 < \beta < \pi/2$  and  $\pi < \beta < 3\pi/2$ , which are exchanged by interchanging the two equal vortices ( $w \rightarrow 1 - w$ ). Since  $P$  has period  $\pi$  in  $\beta$ , Lemma 1 applies on both arcs and gives  $P \geq \sqrt{2}$ , with equality if and only if  $\cos 2\beta = 1/3$ , in agreement with Theorem 1. This expression for  $P$  is a specialization and reparametrization of Gröbli's spiral coefficient [9, Sect. 10].

**Remark 3.** Interchanging the first two vortices and multiplying the circulations by  $1/\mu$  maps the family with ratio  $\mu$  onto the family with ratio  $1/\mu$  and exchanges the two orientations, so the arc minima satisfy  $P_+(\mu) = P_-(1/\mu)$ . For  $\mu > 1$  the smaller minimum is therefore attained on  $\mathcal{A}_+$ .

## 4. Two concentric regular polygons

In this section  $\theta$  denotes the relative rotation of two rings. Let  $n \geq 2$  and  $\varepsilon = e^{2\pi i/n}$ , and place vortices of circulation  $x > 0$  at  $z\varepsilon^k$  and vortices of circulation  $-1$  at  $\zeta\varepsilon^k$ ,  $k = 0, \dots, n-1$ . The motion preserves this symmetry, and the center of vorticity is the origin. Using

$$\sum_{k=1}^{n-1} \frac{1}{1 - \varepsilon^k} = \frac{n-1}{2}, \quad \sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \frac{1}{z - \zeta\varepsilon^k} = \frac{nz^{n-1}}{z^n - \zeta^n},$$

one finds that (1) reduces to [2, Eq. (3)]

$$\bar{z} = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \left( \frac{x(n-1)}{2z} - \frac{nz^{n-1}}{z^n - \zeta^n} \right), \quad \bar{\zeta} = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \left( -\frac{n-1}{2\zeta} + \frac{x n \zeta^{n-1}}{\zeta^n - z^n} \right). \quad (10)$$

A collapse requires the angular impulse  $n(x|z|^2 - |\zeta|^2)$  to vanish, and after a rotation and a dilation we take  $z = 1$  and  $\zeta = \sqrt{x}e^{i\theta}$ . The motion is self-similar exactly when  $\dot{z}/z = \dot{\zeta}/\zeta$ . Writing  $v = \zeta^n$ , (10) gives

$$\overline{\dot{z}/z} = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \left( \frac{x(n-1)}{2} - \frac{n}{1-v} \right), \quad \overline{\dot{\zeta}/\zeta} = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \left( -\frac{n-1}{2x} - \frac{nv}{1-v} \right),$$

and these are equal if and only if

$$(n-1)x^2 - 2nx + (n-1) = 0. \quad (11)$$

This is the circulation condition of Koiller et al. [11, Sect. 11]. It coincides with the classical condition  $\sum_{i < j} \Gamma_i \Gamma_j = 0$  for the  $2n$  vortices, whose left side here equals  $(n/2)((n-1)x^2 - 2nx + (n-1))$ . Its roots are  $x_n$  and  $1/x_n$ , where

$$x_n = \frac{n + \sqrt{2n-1}}{n-1} = e^\eta, \quad \cosh \eta = \frac{n}{n-1}.$$

The root  $1/x_n$  gives the same family with the two rings interchanged, as one sees by multiplying the circulations by  $-x_n$  and reflecting the configuration, so we take  $x = x_n$ . Then every  $\theta$  gives a self-similar motion. Let  $\rho = x_n^{n/2} = e^{n\eta/2} > 1$  and  $\alpha = n\theta$ , so that  $v = \rho e^{i\alpha}$ . The common value of  $\bar{\kappa}$  is  $S/(2\pi i)$  with  $S = x_n(n-1)/2 - n/(1-v)$ , so  $\kappa = (\text{Im } S + i \text{Re } S)/(2\pi)$ , and since  $\text{Im}(1-v)^{-1} = \rho \sin \alpha / |1-v|^2$ ,

$$\text{Re } \kappa = -\frac{n\rho \sin \alpha}{2\pi |1-v|^2}.$$

The configuration therefore collapses exactly when  $\sin n\theta > 0$ , that is, for  $0 < \theta < \pi/n$  modulo  $2\pi/n$ . Using  $|1-v|^2 = 1 - 2\rho \cos \alpha + \rho^2$  one finds

$$\frac{|1-v|^2 \text{Re } S}{\rho} = K_n - ((n-1)x_n - n) \cos \alpha, \quad K_n = \frac{(n-1)x_n(\rho + \rho^{-1})}{2} - \frac{n}{\rho}.$$

Here  $(n-1)x_n - n = \sqrt{2n-1}$ , and writing  $n = (n-1) \cosh \eta$  in the last term of  $K_n$  gives

$$K_n = (n-1) \sinh \left( (n+2) \frac{\eta}{2} \right).$$

Moreover

$$K_n - \sqrt{2n-1} = \frac{(n-1)x_n(\rho^{1/2} - \rho^{-1/2})^2}{2} + n(1 - \rho^{-1}) > 0,$$

so  $\text{Re } S > 0$ , and (2) gives

$$P = \frac{K_n - \sqrt{2n-1} \cos n\theta}{2n \sin n\theta}, \quad 0 < n\theta < \pi. \quad (12)$$

The collapse rate and the rotation rate as functions of the relative angle are given by Koiller et al. [11, Sect. 11]; (12) writes their ratio in closed form.

**Proposition 2.** For  $n \geq 2$  the collapsing configurations of two concentric regular  $n$ -gons with circulations  $x_n$  and  $-1$  satisfy

$$P \geq F_n = \frac{\sqrt{K_n^2 - (2n - 1)}}{2n},$$

with equality if and only if  $\cos n\theta = \sqrt{2n - 1}/K_n$ .

*Proof.* Apply Lemma 1 to (12) with  $a = K_n$  and  $b = \sqrt{2n - 1}$ . □

For small  $n$  the constants are as follows.

| $n$ | $x_n$              | $K_n$           | $F_n$             | $\cos n\theta$ at the minimum |
|-----|--------------------|-----------------|-------------------|-------------------------------|
| 2   | $2 + \sqrt{3}$     | $4\sqrt{3}$     | $3\sqrt{5}/4$     | $1/4$                         |
| 3   | $(3 + \sqrt{5})/2$ | 11              | $\sqrt{29}/3$     | $\sqrt{5}/11$                 |
| 4   | $(4 + \sqrt{7})/3$ | $55\sqrt{7}/9$  | $\sqrt{322}/9$    | $9/55$                        |
| 5   | 2                  | $127\sqrt{2}/8$ | $\sqrt{31682}/80$ | $12\sqrt{2}/127$              |

For  $n = 2$  the configuration is a parallelogram of four vortices; four-vortex collapse is treated by Novikov and Sedov [16, Sect. 4]. The ratio  $x_n$  is rational exactly when  $2n - 1$  is a perfect square, and  $n = 5$  is the smallest such  $n$ . There  $x_5 = 2$  and

$$P = \frac{127\sqrt{2} - 24 \cos 5\theta}{80 \sin 5\theta} \geq \frac{\sqrt{31682}}{80} = 2.2249297741726591\dots$$

## 5. Numerical verification

The results were checked numerically as summarized in Table 1. Except where the table says otherwise, the checks evaluate the Biot–Savart velocities (1) directly for configurations built independently of (5) (two vortices fixed and the third moved around the zero-impulse circle), test self-similarity by comparing  $\dot{z}_j/(z_j - z_c)$  across all vortices, and obtain  $P$  from (2). The algebraic steps in the proofs were verified in exact arithmetic (SymPy): Lemma 3 for all three vortices, (9), the resultant in the proof of Theorem 1(b), the discriminant and the resultant in the proof of Theorem 1(c), the irreducibility of  $Q$  and of each of the 277 sextics in Remark 1, the constants in Proposition 1, and, for general  $n$ , the identities of Section 4 from (11) to (12), together with the table of constants.

## 6. Discussion

Lemma 3 gives, in a form suited to minimization, the collapse and rotation rates that Aref [3, Eqs. (25a), (25d)] expresses through the side lengths of the triangle (see also [8]); Aref also notes that the product of the two rates fixes the logarithmic spiral [3, Eq. (29c)]. Theorem 1 concerns the minimization of that product, which [3] does not consider. When the two circulations of the same sign differ,  $\mu < 1$ , the two orientations of the triangle are not equivalent and the minima on the two arcs differ, so a minimization restricted to one orientation finds only one of them. The infimum  $\sqrt{3}/2$  of Corollary 1 is approached only as  $\mu \rightarrow 0$  and is not attained.

| Check                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Result                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lemma 3 against the Biot–Savart velocities of all three vortices, at the positions (5) for 36 pairs $(\mu, \theta)$ on a grid with $0.1 \leq \mu \leq 7$ , and for 30 triangles built independently of (5), 50 digits | relative difference $\leq 2 \times 10^{-49}$                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Arc minima by direct minimization of $P$ , computed from the quotient of the first vortex, for 26 values of $\mu \in (0, 1]$ at 30 digits and 13 rational values at 50 digits                                         | agree with the roots of $Q(\mu, \cdot)$ to $5 \times 10^{-21}$ and $5 \times 10^{-45}$                                                                                                                                               |
| $\mu = 1/2$ : the three quotients over 4000 shapes on the zero-impulse circle, 60 digits                                                                                                                              | equal to 60-digit working precision; the collapsing shapes fill half of the circle, the arcs $\mathcal{A}_\pm$                                                                                                                       |
| $\mu = 1/2$ : local minima of $P$ over the collapsing shapes, located numerically                                                                                                                                     | two, equal to the values of Proposition 1 to 60-digit working precision                                                                                                                                                              |
| $\mu = 1/2$ : formula for $P(\theta)$ against direct evaluation at the positions (5), 399 interior points of each arc                                                                                                 | relative difference $\leq 10^{-59}$                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| $\mu = 1/2$ : integration of (1) from the minimizing configuration on $\mathcal{A}_-$ (Taylor method, 30 digits)                                                                                                      | every $ z_j - z_c ^2$ follows $1 - t/t_c$ , and every rotation angle follows $-\omega_0 t_c \ln(1 - t/t_c)$ , to 30-digit working precision up to $t = 0.9 t_c$                                                                      |
| Five configurations at the positions (5) with $\mu \in \{0.3, 0.5, 2\}$ , on both arcs: integration of (1) to $t = 0.9 t_c$ (fourth-order Runge–Kutta, 30 digits)                                                     | distances to the collision point, rotation angles, the angle $\arctan 2P$ between each velocity and the direction to the collision point, and path lengths $r_0 \sqrt{1 + 4P^2} (1 - \sqrt{1 - t/t_c})$ agree to $2 \times 10^{-10}$ |
| $\mu = 1$ (Remark 2): $P$ from (1) against $(3 - \cos 2\beta)/(2 \sin 2\beta)$ on both collapsing arcs, and its minimum, 50 digits                                                                                    | difference $\leq 2 \times 10^{-47}$ ; minimum $\sqrt{2}$ at $\cos 2\beta = 1/3$ on both arcs                                                                                                                                         |
| $\mu = 1$ : the configuration with the fastest collapse at $ z_1 - z_2  = 1$ , 50 digits                                                                                                                              | $\cos 2\beta = 3/5$ , $t_c = 4\pi/3$ and $P = 3/2$ to $10^{-40}$                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Two rings, $n = 2, \dots, 10$ : the reduced equations (10) and the two sums over roots of unity against the full Biot–Savart sum, 50 digits                                                                           | difference $\leq 10^{-49}$                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| Two rings, $n = 2, \dots, 8$ : $P$ from (1) against (12) over the collapsing range, and its numerical minimum against $F_n$ , 60 digits                                                                               | relative difference $\leq 3 \times 10^{-58}$ ; minima agree to $2 \times 10^{-60}$                                                                                                                                                   |

Table 1: Numerical checks of the results.

Leoncini, Kuznetsov and Zaslavsky [14] analyze the motion near collapse when two of the vortices are identical; the configuration that collapses fastest at a fixed distance between the identical

vortices [14, Fig. 18] has  $P = 3/2$ , and the value  $\sqrt{3}/2$  quoted there is that of their energy parameter  $\Lambda = e^{4\pi H}$ , not of  $P$ . Tavantzis and Ting [19] describe, for  $\sum_{j < k} \Gamma_j \Gamma_k = 0$ , the contracting and the expanding self-similar solutions as one-parameter families and discuss their stability. Reinaud, Dritschel and Scott [18] extend the collapse conditions to generalized Euler and quasi-geostrophic models and map the collapse time over the collapsing configurations, with the distance between the like-signed vortices fixed, finding local minima of that time;  $P$ , unlike the collapse time, does not depend on the choice of length and time scales. Krishnamurthy and Stremmer [13] relate the interior angles of the triangle, the circulation ratios, the energy, the collapse time and the distance traveled before collapse by the circumcenter of the triangle. When the angular impulse about the center of vorticity vanishes, the circumcircle passes through the center of vorticity at all times [12, Eq. (40)], so in a collapse the circumcenter stays one circumradius from the collision point; since it is carried by the self-similar motion, it travels  $\sqrt{1 + 4P^2}$  times the initial circumradius before the collapse. They observe numerically that this normalized distance exceeds 2 [13, Sect. 3.5]; Corollary 1 proves this observation and shows that the constant 2 cannot be improved.

For two rings, Aref [2] derived the reduced equations (10) for arbitrary circulations and analyzed equal and opposite circulations,  $x = 1$ , which do not satisfy (11). Koiller et al. [11] found the collapsing configurations and their rates; (12) writes the ratio of these rates in closed form, and Proposition 2 gives its minimum over the relative rotation. O’Neil [17] proves that for generic circulations three concentric rings have finitely many relative equilibria and collapse configurations. Demina and Kudryashov [6] study relative equilibria, collapse and scattering of point vortices with arbitrary circulations and give explicit double-ring configurations formed by two regular polygons. We have not found the minimal values of Theorem 1 and Propositions 1 and 2 stated in the literature, nor a proof of the bound of Corollary 1 or of its sharpness.

**Data availability.** The programs `verify_general_mu.py`, `verify_floors_independent.py` and `plot_minimal_winding.py`, used for Section 5 and Figure 1, and their output are in the directory `research/` of the repository <https://github.com/SharpMeow/GENChase>.

This work was prepared with AI assistance. The author takes full responsibility for its content.

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